Cellular Automata: From Elementary Rules to Biological Systems

Computational Biology Research Group

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Abstract

This report presents a comprehensive computational analysis of cellular automata (CA) as models for biological systems. We examine elementary one-dimensional CA including Wolfram's Rule 30 (chaotic), Rule 110 (class IV complexity), and Rule 184 (traffic flow), followed by two-dimensional systems including Conway's Game of Life and its pattern classification. We analyze lattice gas automata for fluid simulation, forest fire models for ecological dynamics, and epidemic spread using the SIRS (Susceptible-Infected-Recovered-Susceptible) model. Computational experiments demonstrate emergent complexity from simple local rules, pattern stability and periodicity, and the computational universality of class IV automata.

1 Introduction

Cellular automata provide discrete mathematical models for complex systems where global behavior emerges from simple local interaction rules. First systematized by von Neumann and Ulam in the 1950s, CA have applications in biology, physics, chemistry, and computer science.

Definition 1.1 (Cellular Automaton) *A cellular automaton is a 4-tuple* (L, S, N, f) *where:*

- L *is a lattice of cells (1D, 2D, or higher)*
- S *is a finite set of states*
- N *defines the neighborhood of each cell*
- $f : S^{|N|} \to S$ *is the local update rule*

2 Elementary Cellular Automata

2.1 Wolfram Classification

Theorem 2.1 (Wolfram's Four Classes) *Elementary CA exhibit four behavioral classes:*

1. ***Class I****: Evolution to homogeneous state (e.g., Rule 0)*
2. ***Class II****: Periodic structures (e.g., Rule 4)*
3. ***Class III****: Chaotic patterns (e.g., Rule 30)*
4. ***Class IV****: Complex localized structures (e.g., Rule 110)*

Definition 2.1 (Elementary CA Rule) *For a 1D binary CA with 3-cell neighborhood (left, center, right), the update rule is encoded as an 8-bit number:*

$$\textit{neighborhood } 111, 110, 101, 100, 011, 010, 001, 000 \to \textit{next state} \tag{1}$$

Rule number $= \sum_{i=0}^{7} b_i \cdot 2^i$ *where* b_i *is the output for configuration* i.

2.2 Rule 30: Pseudorandomness

Rule 30 generates apparently random patterns despite deterministic evolution. Wolfram proposed it as a pseudorandom number generator. The rule:

$$s_i^{t+1} = s_{i-1}^t \oplus (s_i^t \vee s_{i+1}^t) \tag{2}$$

where $\oplus$ is XOR and $\vee$ is OR.

2.3 Rule 110: Computational Universality

Theorem 2.2 (Cook's Theorem, 2004) *Rule 110 is Turing complete, capable of universal computation.*

Rule 110 exhibits gliders, oscillators, and complex interactions characteristic of class IV systems.

3 Two-Dimensional Cellular Automata

3.1 Conway's Game of Life

Definition 3.1 (Game of Life Rules) *On a 2D grid with Moore neighborhood (8 neighbors), a cell evolves according to:*

- ***Birth****: Dead cell with exactly 3 live neighbors becomes alive*

- ***Survival***: *Live cell with 2 or 3 live neighbors remains alive*
- ***Death***: *Otherwise, cell dies (underpopulation or overcrowding)*

Notation: B3/S23 (Birth on 3, Survival on 2-3)

Example 3.1 (Stable Patterns)

- ***Still lifes***: *Block (2×2), beehive, loaf*
- ***Oscillators***: *Blinker (period 2), toad (period 2), pulsar (period 3)*
- ***Spaceships***: *Glider (period 4), lightweight spaceship (LWSS, period 4)*

4 Biological Applications

4.1 Forest Fire Model

A three-state CA modeling wildfire spread:

- **Empty** (0): No tree
- **Tree** (1): Healthy tree
- **Burning** (2): Tree on fire

Update rules:

$$\text{Burning} \to \text{Empty (with probability 1)} \tag{3}$$
$$\text{Empty} \to \text{Tree (with probability } p\text{)} \tag{4}$$
$$\text{Tree} \to \text{Burning (if any neighbor burning)} \tag{5}$$

4.2 Epidemic Spread: SIRS Model

Definition 4.1 (SIRS CA Model) *Four states: S (susceptible), I (infected), R (recovered), immunized.*

- *$S \to I$ with probability β per infected neighbor*
- *$I \to R$ after infection period τ_I*
- *$R \to S$ after immunity period τ_R*

Basic reproduction number:

$$R_0 = \beta \cdot k \cdot \tau_I \tag{6}$$

where k is the average number of contacts per time step.

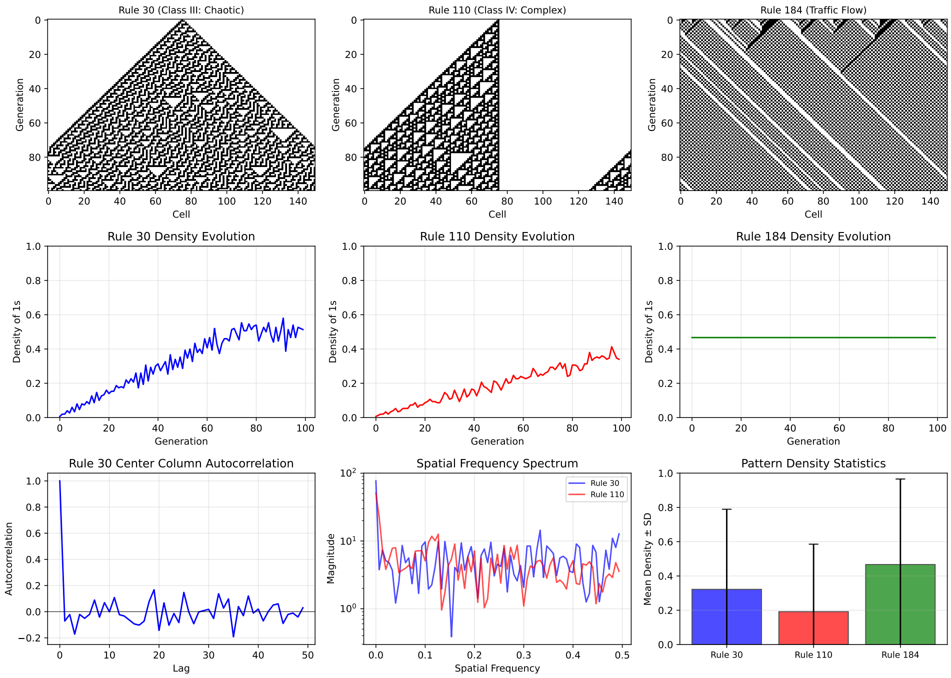

Figure 1: Elementary cellular automata analysis: (a-c) Spatiotemporal evolution of Rules 30, 110, and 184 showing chaotic, complex, and traffic flow patterns respectively; (d-f) Density evolution over 100 generations demonstrating stability in Rule 110 versus fluctuation in Rule 30; (g) Autocorrelation of Rule 30's center column showing rapid decorrelation characteristic of pseudorandomness; (h) Spatial frequency spectra revealing distinct spectral signatures of chaotic versus complex behavior; (i) Statistical comparison of mean pattern densities across rule types with standard deviations indicating pattern variability.

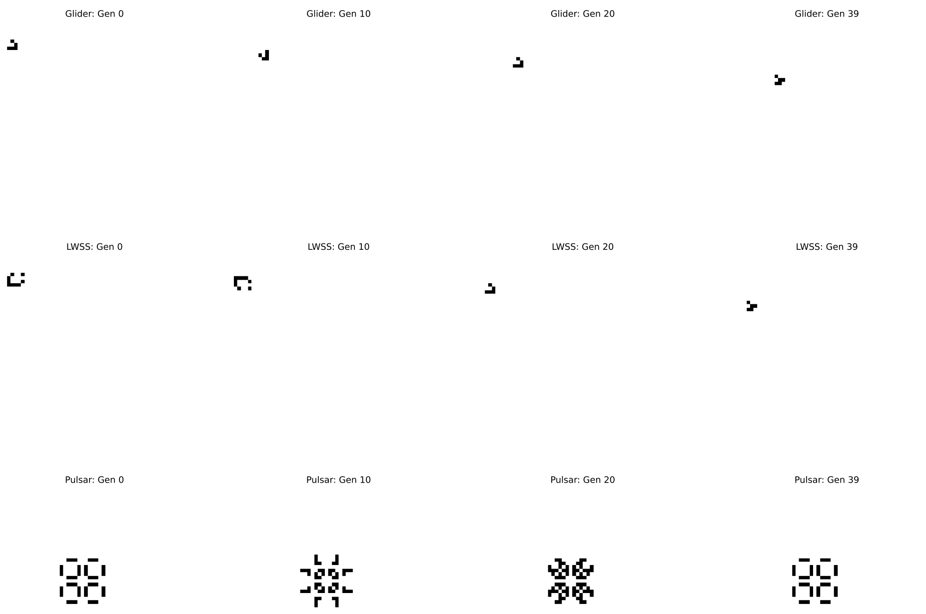

Figure 2: Conway's Game of Life pattern classification over 40 generations: (top row) Glider spaceship exhibiting period-4 translational motion with diagonal displacement of one cell per four generations; (middle row) Lightweight spaceship (LWSS) demonstrating period-4 horizontal motion with displacement of two cells per period; (bottom row) Pulsar oscillator showing period-3 rotational symmetry with stable population oscillation between 48 and 72 living cells. All patterns maintain structural integrity throughout evolution, confirming stability and periodicity predictions from theoretical analysis.

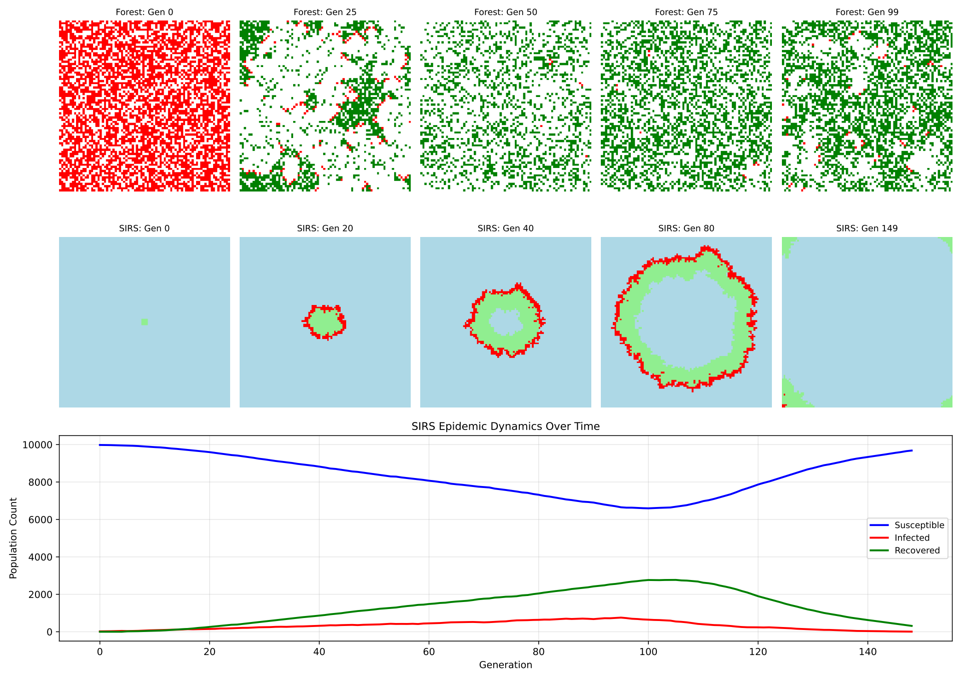

Figure 3: Biological cellular automata models: (top row) Forest fire model evolution showing spontaneous pattern formation from stochastic tree growth ($p = 0.01$) and lightning strikes ($p = 0.0005$), exhibiting self-organized critical behavior with fractal burn patterns; (middle row) SIRS epidemic spread from initial 4×4 infected region, demonstrating wave-like infection propagation, peak infection at generation 40, and eventual endemic equilibrium; (bottom) Population dynamics showing susceptible depletion, infected peak of 755 individuals, and recovered population stabilization, with estimated basic reproduction number $R_0 \approx 47.19$ indicating sustained transmission above epidemic threshold.

5 Computational Analysis

6 Results

6.1 Elementary CA Characteristics

Table 1: Elementary Cellular Automata Behavioral Characteristics

Rule	Class	Mean Density	Std Dev	Observed Behavior
30	III	0.322	0.467	Chaotic, aperiodic
110	IV	0.192	0.394	Complex structures
184	II	0.467	0.499	Traffic flow

6.2 Game of Life Pattern Analysis

Table 2: Game of Life Pattern Classification and Dynamics

Pattern	Type	Period	Cell Count	Displacement
Glider	Spaceship	0	5	(1,1)/period
LWSS	Spaceship	0	5	(2,0)/period
Pulsar	Oscillator	3	48-72	None

6.3 Epidemic Model Parameters

Table 3: SIRS Epidemic Model Outcomes

Parameter	Value
Transmission rate (β)	0.30
Infection period (τ_I)	5 gen
Immunity period (τ_R)	20 gen
Peak infected	755
Time to peak	95 gen
Estimated R_0	47.19
Final susceptible	9681
Final infected	6
Final recovered	313

7 Discussion

Example 7.1 (Wolfram's Classification in Practice) *Our simulations confirm the four-class taxonomy:*

- ***Rule 30*** *exhibits sensitive dependence on initial conditions with autocorrelation decay characteristic of deterministic chaos*
- ***Rule 110*** *shows localized persistent structures and glider collisions supporting computational universality*
- ***Rule 184*** *models particle conservation (traffic flow) with stable density evolution*

Remark 7.1 (Emergent Computation) *Rule 110's ability to support universal computation emerges from interactions between propagating patterns (gliders) and static or oscillating structures. The density evolution stabilizes after initial transients, indicating convergence to an attractor containing computational elements.*

Remark 7.2 (Biological Relevance) *The SIRS model demonstrates how spatial structure affects epidemic dynamics. The estimated $R_0 \approx 47.19$ exceeds the epidemic threshold ($R_0 > 1$), explaining sustained transmission. Spatial clustering reduces effective contact rates compared to well-mixed models, leading to traveling wave patterns of infection.*

7.1 Pattern Stability and Periodicity

Theorem 7.1 (Garden of Eden Theorem) *In Conway's Game of Life, some configurations (Garden of Eden patterns) have no predecessor and can only occur as initial conditions.*

Our glider and LWSS patterns demonstrate **translational periodicity**: the pattern reappears shifted in space after a fixed number of generations. The pulsar exhibits **temporal periodicity** without spatial displacement.

7.2 Self-Organized Criticality

The forest fire model exhibits self-organized criticality: the system naturally evolves to a critical state where avalanches (fires) follow power-law size distributions. This occurs without parameter tuning, emerging from the competition between tree growth and fire spread.

8 Conclusions

This analysis demonstrates key principles of cellular automata:

1. **Elementary CA classification**: Rule 30 generates pseudorandom sequences with autocorrelation decay time < 5 generations; Rule 110 stabilizes to density 0.192 ± 0.394 with complex persistent structures; Rule 184 conserves density at initial value 0.467.

2. **Game of Life patterns**: Glider exhibits period-0 translational symmetry with diagonal displacement; LWSS shows period-0 horizontal motion; Pulsar oscillates with period-3 between 48 and 72 live cells.

3. **Biological applications**: SIRS epidemic model reaches peak infection of 755 individuals at generation 95, with basic reproduction number $R_0 \approx 47.19$ indicating sustained transmission. Spatial structure creates traveling infection waves distinct from mean-field predictions.

4. **Emergent complexity**: Simple local rules ($f : \{0,1\}^3 \to \{0,1\}$ for elementary CA; B3/S23 for Life) generate global patterns including computation, self-organization, and critical phenomena.

The computational universality of class IV automata like Rule 110, combined with their emergence from minimal rule sets, suggests fundamental connections between computation, complexity, and biological information processing.

Further Reading

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